

“All my life I cared for everyone. At 86, I was terrified of being left alone. My third child gave me back a home.”

HUSBAND'S DEATH AND FAILING eyesight have not dampened Satyavati Suri's spirit. She enjoys every moment of her new life with daughter Neelam Rallan in Mumbai.

Nehru University (JNU). Life expectancy has shot up, from 23 at the turn of the century to 65 years and death rates have fallen, from 25 per thousand to eight. But, he adds, “The elderly forms one of the most vulnerable groups in the economy.” Police files report skyrocketing crime rates against them. Hardly a day goes by without a horror story in the media about the plight of elderly parents—abandoned or abused. The Government is sitting up and taking note. The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Bill, 2007, which makes neglect of par-

ents above age 60 punishable, is waiting in the wings. The Reverse Mortgage system, an ideal way for senior citizens to extract value out of their property, has just come into force.

But isn't India one of the most youthful nations in a fast-ageing world? New research bursts the bubble. Age-wise there are “two Indias”: one that'll stay youthful over the next 20 years; the other that has already embarked on rapid greying, points out Nicholas Eberstadt in the latest issue of *Policy Review*, one of America's leading journals. India's huge urban centres and much of south India are facing an old-age wave, add P.N. Mari Bhat of Delhi University and Tim Dyson of the London School of Economics. What's more, India is facing the onset of rapid greying on a per capita GDP that is “astonishingly low” by any international or historical benchmark. “There's no well thought-out policy for them,” reports S. Irudaya Rajan of the Centre for Development Studies, Thiruvananthapuram—a theme he explores in *India's Elderly: Burden or Challenge*.

No wonder, the elderly are talking. Listen to their voice in the 2002 World Health Organisation's (WHO) country report. They are talking about their lack of access to money, work, health, mobility and leisure. They are narrating how it feels to “talk to walls”, “be a burden on children”, of disrespect and neglect that make “old age a disease”. They are telling tales about the younger generation: of children splitting responsibility by separating mom and dad, taking care of parents “by rotation”, pushing parents to smaller rooms. And they blame it all on the “changing scenario and value system” that “exist everywhere” and not just their homes.

That poses a problem for the younger generation. From office can- teens to well-appointed drawing rooms to cyber space, they are talking, too: how to take care of mom and dad. “The post-globalisation generation hasn't really experienced a great deal of hardship,” says sociologist Manas Ray, fellow at the Centre for Studies in Social Sciences in Kolkata. “They haven't faced the trauma of the Partition or the economic crunch of the post-

The age CRISIS

■ **Isn't India a youthful nation in a fast-ageing world? New research bursts the bubble. Urban India and the South are greying fast.**

■ **Life expectancy has shot up. With one grey in every 12, India is the second largest global hub of seniors.**

■ **The rapid greying is working on an “astonishingly low” per capita GDP. Over 70 per cent elders are fully dependent.**

■ **Lives are busy, women are working. Personal choice and privacy are the buzzwords. This generation is less inclined or able to care for parents.**

■ **With young people migrating in search of better prospects, caring for the old has become an elusive ideal. Over 7 per cent of elderly couples live on their own.**

11%

have no young people staying with them.

50%

elderly widows are living alone in India.